

4. **Software:** ISPs usually provide a CD-ROM with software that you must use to connect to and use the Internet. This disc already has the software you need.
5. **Technical support:** It would be ideal if you could opt for an ISP that gives you a helpline number that you could call 24 x 7 if you encounter any glitches (and believe us, there could be plenty). Often, these help-lines take ages to actually reach an operator on the other end and however unimportant that seems, think it out—or better, call the number and try it out even before you actually subscribe to the service.
6. **Bandwidth and speed:** How many channels does your ISP claim to manage simultaneously over a single line? How much data do they claim to be able to transmit per second and how much, in reality does get transported?
7. **Accessibility:** if you're using a modem, the busy signal is possibly going to be one of your daily hindrances in attempting to access the Internet. You could waste a lot of time dialling and redialling. The best way to check this out would be to ask the Internet users in the same area whether they face difficulties in getting connected to the ISP you are intending to subscribe to.
8. **Latency:** It would be to your benefit if you could get an idea of the latency (delay in data transmission) problems that occur if you use a particular ISP. Latency is basically the amount of time a packet of data needs to reach from one point in the network to another.

### **1.1.5 Identifying ISPs In Your Area Or City:**

1. Ask friends. Actually, even ask your enemies. There's nothing like getting the low-down straight from the horse's mouth. People who already use the Internet would be ideal to tell you about their experiences with particular ISPs and help you to work out a comparative evaluation of the most optimal one in your area.